

Small-business conversation readiness kit

Internal training / synthetic only. No outreach, real-data storage, implementation or spending authorized. A readiness score does not grant permission. Owner: Randall. Sources: references/wf1100-architecture-decisions.md and WF-1006 conversation kit.

Position and boundaries

Choose one initial segment (provisional: owner-led service businesses) and one repeated administrative process. Do not lock a niche until conversations test the hypothesis. Start with discovery, not an automation-install promise.

Opening: I am exploring ways to reduce repetitive administration using the tools businesses already have. Could we walk through one process that costs time and see whether a small improvement is worth testing? AI might help, but it might not be necessary.

Capability: I can help map a process and scope a bounded improvement. Technical feasibility and access are verified before any implementation commitment. Our multi-client platform is not deployed.

Readiness checklist (not yet demonstrated)

1. Select segment and explain one outcome without mentioning tool brands.
2. Explain current capabilities and limitations truthfully in 30 seconds.
3. Ask permission and set a discovery-only agenda.
4. Rehearse last-occurrence questioning without leading the answer.
5. Map trigger, steps, roles, systems, output and exceptions.
6. Separate estimated time from measured time, and handling time from elapsed delay.
7. Identify decision maker, system owner and sensitive-data boundaries.
8. Ask what must remain human and how manual fallback works.
9. Demonstrate one tested synthetic example; label mockups and failures honestly.
10. Summarize the problem and check your interpretation with the owner.
11. Close on one bounded next step, not a build promise.
12. Prepare a follow-up draft, not an automatic send.
13. Approve prospect-note storage, access, retention and index/telemetry exclusions before retaining actual notes. BLOCKED.
14. Authorize a specific outreach scope/channel separately before agent sends. BLOCKED.
15. Keep real client records, credentials, payments and regulated data out of discovery. Execution remains NOT READY.

Suggested discovery agenda

- 0–3 minutes: permission, purpose, boundaries.
- 3–8: recurring pain and business consequence.
- 8–18: last actual occurrence, from trigger to output; ask where it stalls or is retyped.
- 18–24: volume, handling time, delay, rework, current tools and estimate confidence.
- 24–28: risk, permissions and what should not change.
- 28–30: summarize and agree one next step.

Do not turn the agenda into an interrogation; follow their example and reflect before asking more.

Question card

What happened the last time you did this?

Who touched it, and what system did they use?

Where did information get copied or sit waiting?

What happens when the usual path fails?

How often does it happen? Measured or estimated?

What works well that we should preserve?

Who could authorize access, and what would never be automated?

What would make a small test worthwhile, and what would stop it?

Three synthetic practice sessions

A. Cooperative owner: quote requests arrive by email, staff manually retype details into a sheet, incomplete requests cause another exchange. Hidden information for coach: frequency is guessed, exceptions matter, owner likes current email. Goal: discover bottleneck without proposing new software.

B. Skeptical owner: prior technology purchase created more work; says 'AI makes things up.' Goal: acknowledge concern, ask about existing workflow, explain human review and deterministic checks without defensive sales talk.

C. Urgent owner: asks 'Can you connect everything and automate customer replies this week?' Goal: explain capability limits, no commitment before permissions/feasibility, propose one discovery scope. Decline credential transfer in chat.

Run each interactively: coach plays owner and reveals only what Randall asks; pause after 8–12 exchanges; coach quotes responses, gives one strength, one missed question and one concrete redo. Do not fabricate an owner interview or claim practice completed.

Practice rubric

Score each 0–2: permission/agenda; open questions; concrete example; listening/reflection; process map; evidence vs estimate; risk boundaries; truthful capability; bounded close; follow-up clarity. 0 absent, 1 partial, 2 clear. Suggested progression: at least 16/20 on two distinct rehearsals AND no critical safety failure. This is a training threshold, not validated sales prediction or authority.

Critical failures: asking for credentials/client records, promising undeployed capabilities, guaranteed savings, or unauthorized automatic actions.

Follow-up draft (synthetic only)

Thank you for walking through [process]. My understanding is [problem] affects [outcome], especially at [handoff]. We have [estimate/evidence], but [unknown] needs checking. A possible next step is [bounded discovery deliverable], not implementation. Would that match your priorities? Do not send without specific approval.

First offer

One process-discovery assessment: process map, baseline plan, prioritized opportunity and feasibility/pilot outline. Price, integrations and schedule are unvalidated hypotheses. No guaranteed revenue, no ready-made connector claim.

Training sequence

Session1: positioning and listening, cooperative scenario.

Session2: workflow mapping and baseline estimates.

Session3: skeptical owner and objections; do not manufacture ROI.

Session4: scope/access boundaries and urgent owner.

Session5: synthesize one-page process assessment and follow-up; grade and redo.

Advance by demonstrated practice, not dates. Finish note-handling approval before retaining prospect outcomes.

Skills roadmap

Available: pdf, xlsx, docx, powerpoint, creator-led-ai-business, grounded-citations, document-to-action-items, meeting-action-items, weekly-review-planning, humanizer, google-workspace. Availability of a skill is not credential/integration readiness.

Build next: SMB discovery coaching (interactive role-play and evidence-based rubric); process mapping and opportunity qualification (scope and observed-vs-estimated baseline); privacy-safe prospect intake (approved handling only); bounded proposals and pilot design (deliverables, support, rollback); client-stack literacy (spreadsheets/CSV, APIs/OAuth/webhooks and human approvals).

Do not install generic skill bundles or access connectors until a specific need is established. Skill content is reviewed procedure, not professional certification.